

Formatting with predefined styles for efficient power writing



by Kenton Lee

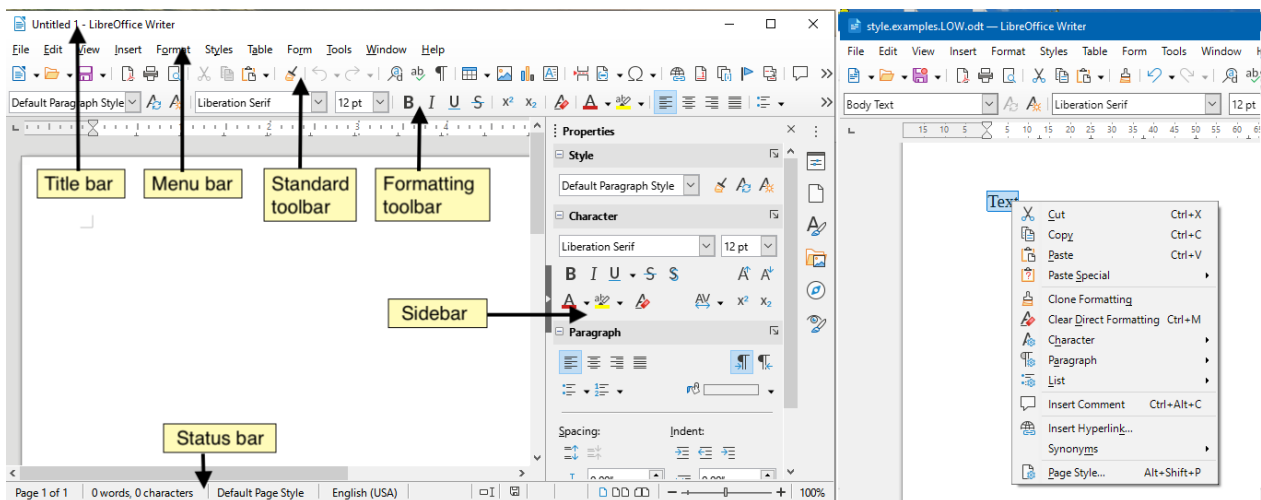
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For years, I have used LibreOffice Writer for all my work, and have generally loved it. It makes it easy for me to write my own course textbooks, write up academic research papers, write PDF guides that I post online, or any document writing needs. The way it handles formatting makes it easy to create large and complex documents, and easily edit the text formatting for the whole document. Also, I can customize the keyboard shortcuts, menu bars, and user interface, and in particular, I can keep a traditional menu bar instead of having to use an MS Word style ribbon. You can use a ribbon a la MS Word if you want to in LibreOffice (LO), but I prefer to keep my screen real estate for my document.

If you are used to using MS Word and decide to try LibreOffice, it helps to understand the LO approach to text formatting. Its text formatting is much more powerful than in MS Word. It may seem more complex at first, but after learning how LO handles formatting, it becomes more powerful and much easier to work with.

When we talk about text formatting, there is a lot more than just the font size and family. Font family refers to font groups like Arial, Times New Roman, Century Schoolbook, Helvetica, Palatino, Trebuchet, and thousands of others. Each family contains subtypes like regular, bold, italic, bold italic, and maybe semi-bold. We often use additional formatting and features that are known as text decoration in web design: italics, boldface, underlining, strike-through, colored font, font shadowing (a shadowing effect on a selection of text), and decoration on headers and subheaders (the titles on headings of sections and subsections),

such as larger or bolder font. Text formatting includes all that, as well as text kerning or letter spacing, subscripts, superscripts, and other effects. This can also include formatting on the entire paragraph, such as alignment and justification, margins, line spacing, and other features. Some features like margins, alignment, and page numbering might also apply to entire page or an entire document. Many of these features can be accessed from the various LO toolbars, main top menu, from the Font Properties sidebar, or by right-clicking and choosing text format features from the pop-up context menu. However, these options apply direct or manual formatting; this may be fine for shorter documents, but for longer documents, using predefined styles will probably be more efficient.



Left: The LibreOffice Writer graphical user interface [from the LibreOffice Writer's Guide, <https://books.libreoffice.org/en/WG72/WG7201-IntroducingWriter.html>], with the Font Properties sidebar.

Right: Right-click context menu for basic font attributes [author's screenshot; unless otherwise noted, other photos are my own].

The LibreOffice approach to formatting

There are two main philosophical differences in how LibreOffice handles formatting. First, the formatting features and elements are divided into different categories, which you can manage and manipulate separately. The main categories are these:

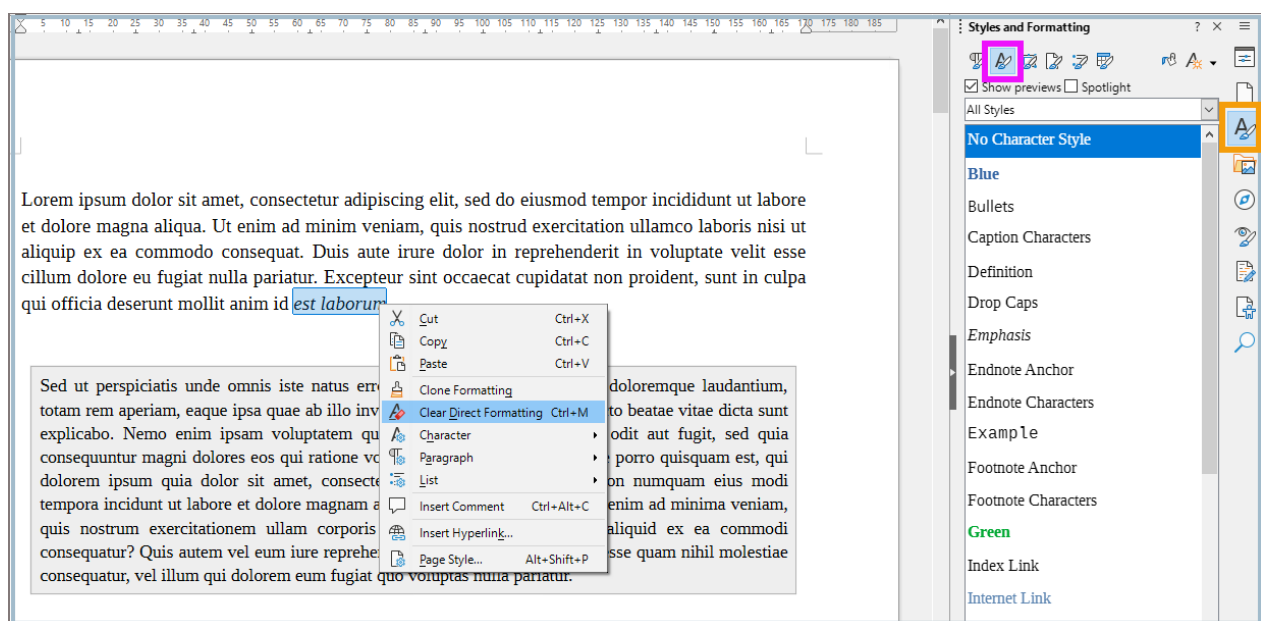
1. Character formatting, which is predefined formatting applied to specific characters or strings of text
2. Paragraph formatting, which applies to an entire paragraph, or a block of text (such as table text, table headers, captions, section headers, chapter titles, and many others)
3. Page formatting, for a whole page or section of a document.

Secondly, the preferred method is to apply predefined styles to text at the appropriate level (character, paragraph, page). In MS Word, you probably manually apply text features to a block or string of text; for example, you highlight a couple of words, right-click, and in the pop-up menu, choose italic font. Or you can use the italics button on the toolbar or ribbon;

or simply use **Ctrl-I** (**Control+I**). This is called **direct formatting** (or manual or special formatting), where formatting features are applied individually, separately, and idiosyncratically to particular portions of text. Word processors can also be configured to convert text marked with asterisks and underscores to bold, italic, and underlined text. You can also directly or manually format text in LibreOffice with the same methods, and for a short document, it may not matter. But for longer documents, direct formatting is much less efficient than applying predefined styles, including your own custom styles.

Relying too much on direct formatting can cause problems in large documents. You may want to modify the formatting on certain types of words or paragraphs, which can get tedious if you have to manually hunt for and change many instances of the text to be modified. This can be arduous, say, if you want to modify some but not all types of italic text.

Also, if you copy and paste text from a web page or other document, you may want to clear some of the text formatting. Depending on the original website, the text pasted into LO may be interpreted according to text tags in the HTML document. You can highlight the text and clear all direct formatting (**Ctrl-M**, or right-click and choose **Clear direct/special formatting**), but it may not work as expected, because LO may have automatically applied predefined character styles rather than direct formatting to the pasted text. It is not Libre's fault; it is probably preserving formatting that exists in the underlying HTML code, which you cannot see. You need to go to the Character Style editor (which is explained in more detail below), highlight the text, and select **No Character Style** to change it.



To clear direct formatting, highlight the text, and then either (1) right-click and select 'Clear Direct Formatting,' or (2) press **Ctrl-M**. If predefined styles were applied, rather than direct formatting, to clear those, open the sidebar, select the Styles & Formatting deck (the icon highlighted in orange), select the Character Style (the icon highlighted in magenta), and double-click on **No Character Style** to remove any styles that were applied.

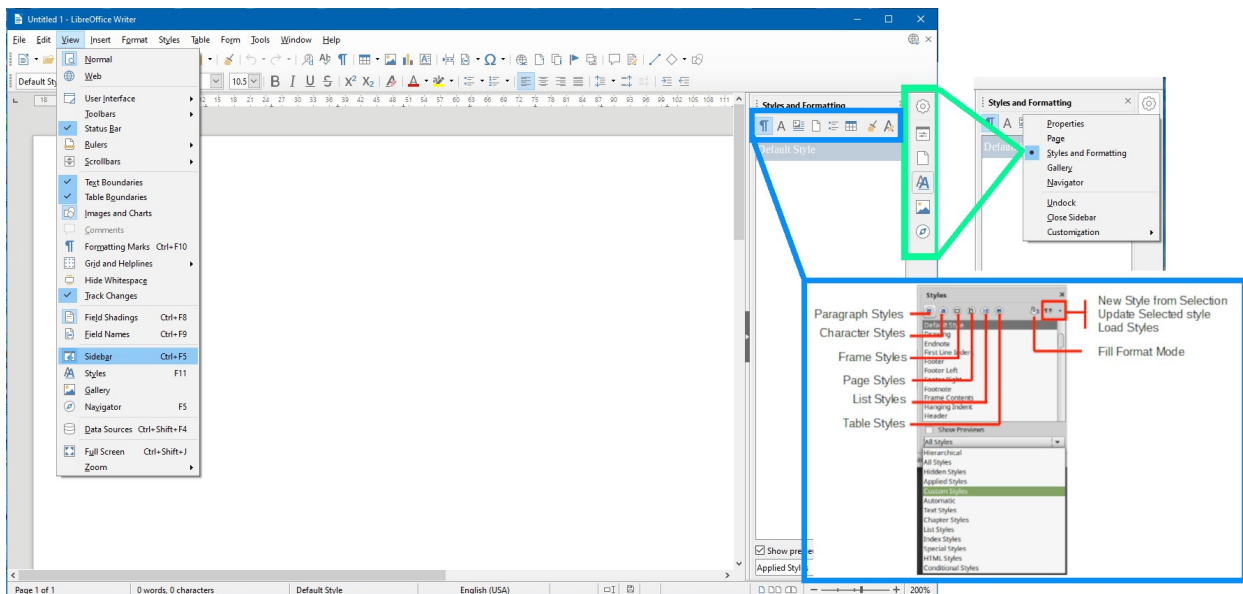
So actually, the logic of LO formatting is similar to the logic of web page elements. Behind the visible text of a web page is the HTML markup language, with tags for different levels of section headers and subheaders (known as [H1](#) for a top-level header, [H2](#) for a subheader, and so on), for regular text paragraphs, for text with special emphasis (bold or italic), [preformatted text](#) (like for code snippets), and for different types of paragraphs, numbered lists, bulleted lists, and many more. There may be more than one HTML tag that can appear as italics, since there are different types and uses for italics (see below).

When creating documents in LibreOffice, applying predefined formats at the page, paragraph, and character level is the preferred method, rather than direct formatting. This actually makes formatting much easier to manage. For example, let's say you want to change the text format on all second-level section headers. Instead of changing them all manually, or looking through the klunky formatting tool in MS Word, in LibreOffice you can go to the paragraph styles menu, select the [Header 2](#) format (like [H2](#) in web pages), and change its font attributes in one menu. Then the changes will apply to all [H2](#) headers automatically throughout the whole document. If you created some paragraphs or text blocks with different formatting than standard text paragraphs, and then you want to modify the appearance of those text blocks, you can easily edit that text block style. Then all text blocks in the document will be updated automatically, and only those paragraphs marked with the text block style. You can also change how certain italic text appears by modifying the relevant italic character style in the style editor, and changes apply instantly through the whole document. Cool, right?

The sidebar

So let's go through the different style levels, starting with paragraph style, which is probably what you will use most often. You will need to have the style editor displayed in the sidebar. You may see a sidebar or some sidebar icons on one side of the LibreOffice window; if you do not see it, try [Ctrl-F5](#), or from the top menu, [> View > Sidebar](#). This brings up the sidebar, which may first appear as a floating element that you can move around. It will be easier to dock it to the left or right side. Grab it with your mouse and pull it over to whichever side you prefer, until it docks and locks into place (you may need to hold [Ctrl-Shift-F10](#) while doing so if it does not want to dock).

The sidebar has a number of functions that are organized into so-called **decks**. These decks are accessed by the icons on the side of the sidebar: the Properties, Styles, Navigator, and other decks. We specifically want the Styles deck, with the title "Style & Formatting" at the top of the deck. You can find the Styles icon, or press [Alt-2](#) to see it. This should not be confused with the Properties deck (probably the topmost icon), which also shows font and text features, but this is for direct formatting, that is, manually applied special formatting, rather than for using the predefined styles that we want.



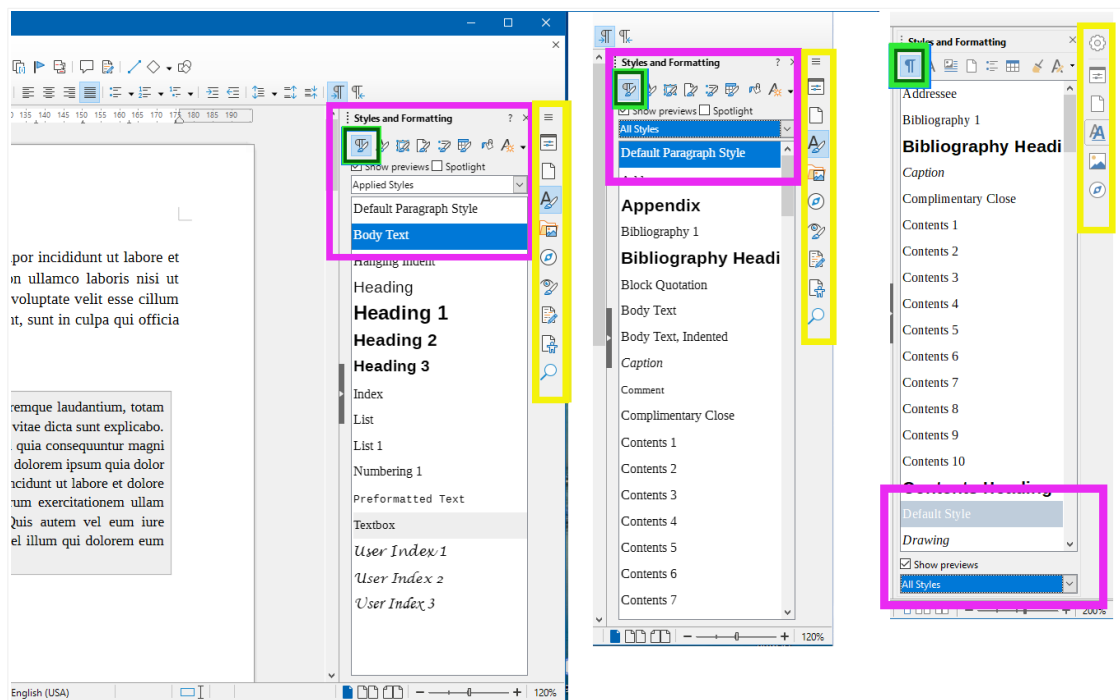
On the left, you can find and activate the sidebar from the top menu. The different sidebar decks can be seen in the green box and lines, which highlight the Styles & Formatting deck. The blue rectangle and box show the different style menus: Paragraph, Character, Frame, Page, and others [blue square, bottom right: from the LibreOffice Writer's Guide, books.libreoffice.org, showing an older version of LO Writer] .

Tips:

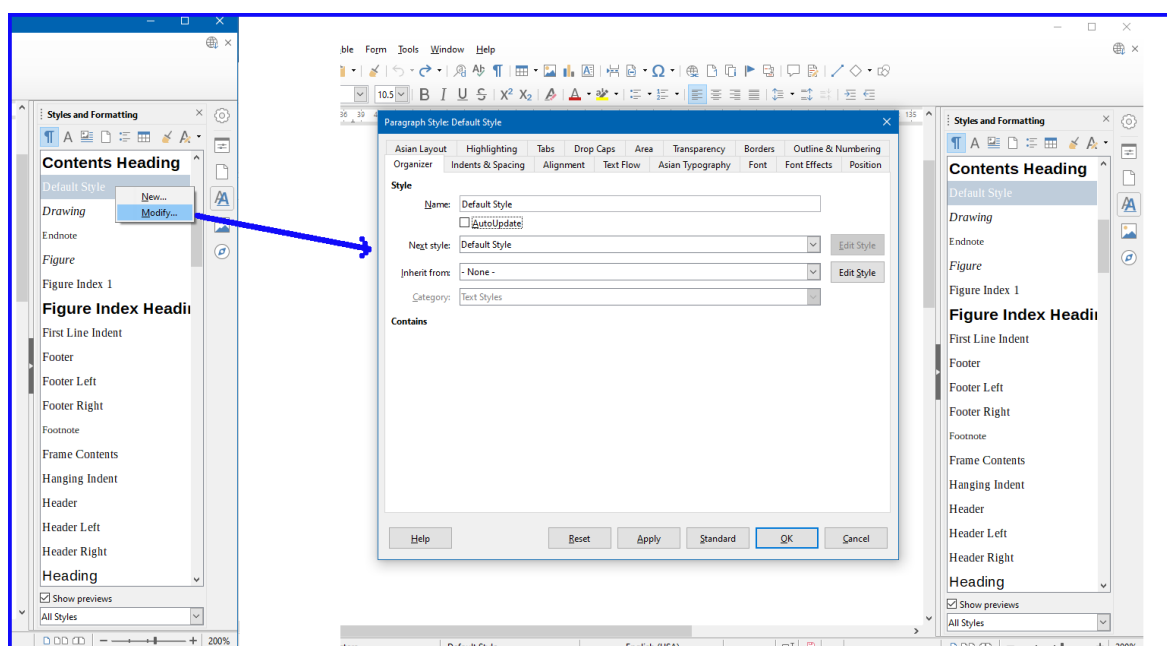
- The Navigator deck of the sidebar is also handy for navigating large, complex documents, as it shows all the different levels and sections of the document. I usually invoke a second sidebar with the Navigator on it, and dock it to the other side of my LibreOffice workspace.
- You can also customize one of the top toolbars (above the document workspace) with some style selection functions, but the Styles deck of the sidebar is easier to work with.

Paragraph styles

On the Styles deck, right under the title **Styles and Formatting** on the top, there are some icons for the different style sets. Going from left to right, they are: Paragraph styles, Character styles, Frame styles, List styles, Table styles, and (in some LO versions) possibly others that are not so important here. Select the Paragraph styles icon on the far left to display the paragraph styles menu. There is a drop-down menu to view only Applied Styles, that is, only those currently used in the document, or All Styles (including a large number of predefined styles that come with LO), and other options (a hierarchical view, good for when you are using a lot of styles; automatic view, for some default styles, and so on). The predefined styles include things like different heading levels, body or main text (called **Body Text**, or **Text Body** in older LO versions), titles, table elements (table text, captions, headers), bulleted lists, and many others. The one called **Default Style** or **Default Paragraph Style** is the base default style, and the basis for all other styles; it is also useful as a starting point for creating your own custom styles.



The sidebar is shown for several different versions of Libre: The deck selection on the right is highlighted in yellow; the style icon (in green); and in the magenta box, several items are highlighted: the drop-down menu for "Applied Styles" or "All Styles," the general all-purpose Default Paragraph Style or Default Style, and the default paragraph text style, termed Body Text in newer versions or Text Body / Text Body Single in older versions.



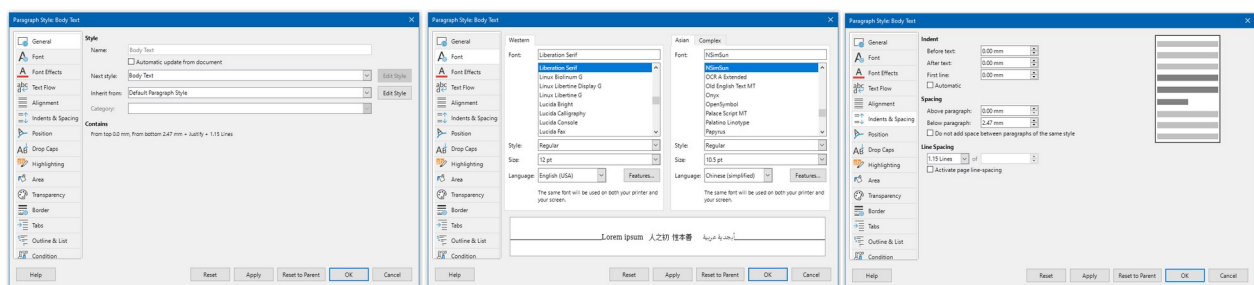
You can right-click on a particular style, select **Modify** and see the style menu dialogue box; here it is shown in an older version of Libre.

To apply a style, put your cursor somewhere in the paragraph or text block you want to stylize, or highlight larger sections with the mouse, and double-click on the style the sidebar that you want to apply. For example, for regular paragraph text, put your cursor in a paragraph and double-click the one you like (Body Text, or Text Body Single). If you want to

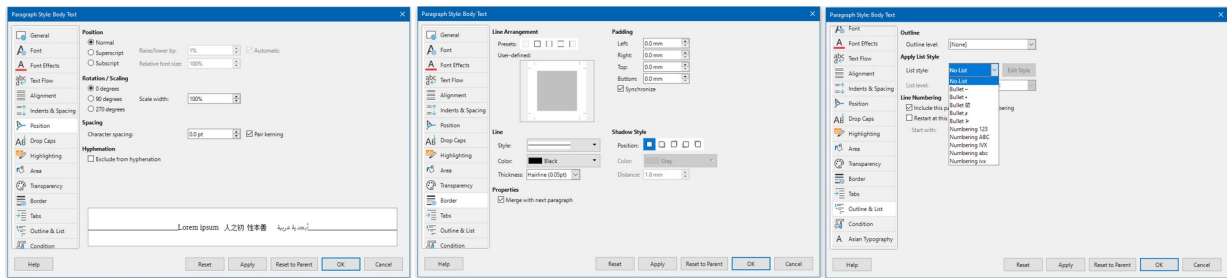
modify all body paragraphs, then in the sidebar, right-click on the style (Text Body Single, in the example below) to chose 'Edit Style.' You will see a menu with a number of options on different tabs at the top (or on the side in some newer versions):

- **General:** Name of the style, and its parent style
- **Font:** font family and size
- **Font effects:** font color, underlining, all capitals, shadow effects, etc.
- **Alignment:** right, center, left, justified, and other related settings
- **Indents & Spacing:** line spacing, space between paragraphs, paragraph-initial indent, making the whole paragraph indented
- **Position:** Letter position (superscript, subscript), rotation, character scaling and spacing or kerning (spacing between letters, e.g., if you need more compact text)
- **Tabs** for creating custom tab positions and layouts
- **Outline / List:** Here you can customize the list type for bullet lists (different bullet shapes) and numbered lists (different numbering systems, like Arabic, Roman, lower case Roman, etc.)
- **Highlighting** and **Area:** For highlighting effects and background effects behind entire text blocks
- **Borders:** This is useful if, say, if you want section headers, or other entire text blocks, to be underlined or boxed.
- **Asian Typography** for East Asian languages

The General tab defines the style name (this cannot be changed for predefined LO styles), the parent style that it was created from (mainly relevant if you create your own custom styles), and the style that automatically applies to the next paragraph (like when you hit enter while in the paragraph). Make your changes, and the changes apply to all text in the document with that paragraph style.



The more modern version of the style editor with tabs on the left side (roughly from version 26 in 2026), showing the **Body Text** style; from left to right: the General tab, the Font tab, and the Indents & Spacing tab.



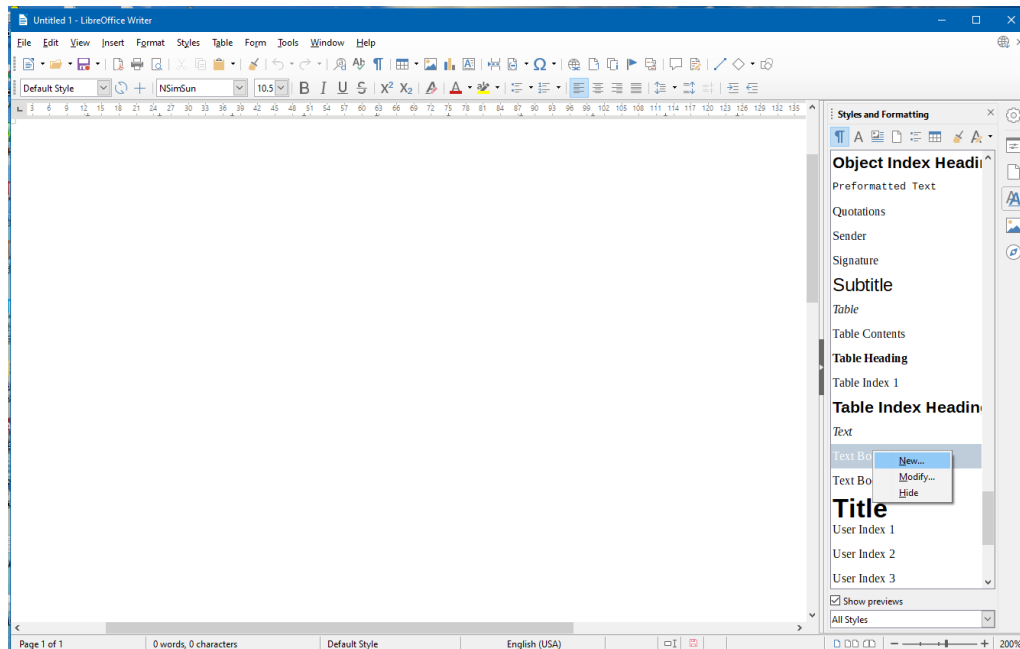
The style editor for the **Body Text** style; from left to right: the Position tab, the Border tab, and the Outline & List tab.

Predefined paragraph styles

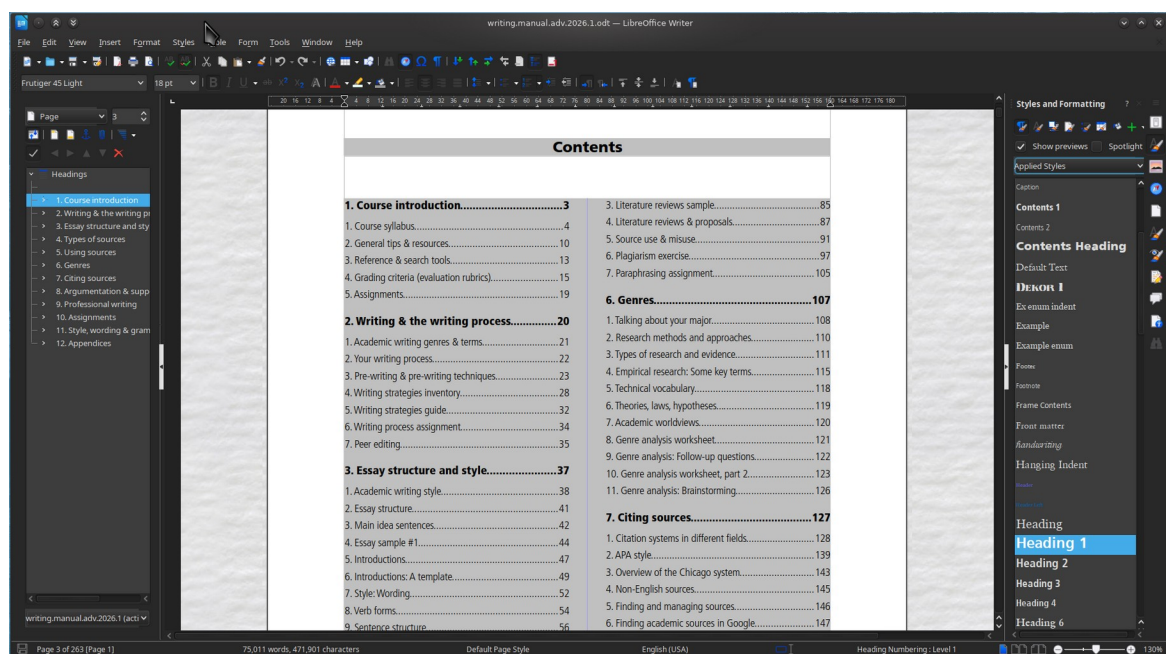
Libre by default comes with predefined paragraph styles for the following types of text blocks.

- **Bibliography** (for bibliographic entries) and **Bibliography Heading**
- **Body text** (general text paragraphs; or Text Body Single for regular single-spaced paragraphs in earlier versions of LO)
- Standard **business letter elements** like **Addressee**, **Complimentary Close**, **Sender**, **Signature**
- **Caption** (for figure, diagram, or table captions)
- **Contents 1-10** and **Contents Heading**: This is for different levels of a table of contents (TOC) that is generated with the TOC tool in LibreOffice; the Content levels correspond to different heading levels in the document, plus **Contents Heading** for the TOC heading
- **Footer** and **Header**--for elements in the page footer and header, such as page numbers, running titles of documents; separate left and right header and footer styles are available as well
- Text for **various inserted elements**, such as **Drawing**, **Figure**, **Figure Index** (for a table of figures), **Frame Contents** (for floating, movable text frame objects), **Illustration**, **Object Index**, and **Appendix** (e.g. appendix header)
- **Endnote** and **Footnote** text and font attributes
- **Heading 1-10**, for different heading and subheader levels in the document
- **Special** text paragraph types, like **Body Text Indented**, **Block Quotation**, **Hanging Indent**, **First Line Indent**, **Preformatted Text** (e.g., for coding examples), **Front Matter** (e.g., for books); also, special elements like **Horizontal Line**
- **Lists**: Different bullet list elements (unordered lists in HTML lingo); up to five different predefined list types are available, which can be customized for different list levels (with different indentations) and bullet types
- **Numbered Lists**: Different numbered list types; up to five different list types for different list levels or types, which can be customized with indentation and list types (Arabic numerals, Roman numerals, or whatever exotic numbering system you like)

- **Table Contents** (main table text), **Table Heading**, **Table Index** (for a table of tables, like a TOC for tables)
- **Title and Subtitle**
- **User Index 1-10**: Fully customizable elements for any purpose



Some of the predefined paragraph styles that come with LibreOffice. When right-clicking on the particular style, you can also choose to create a new style based on that style element (see below).

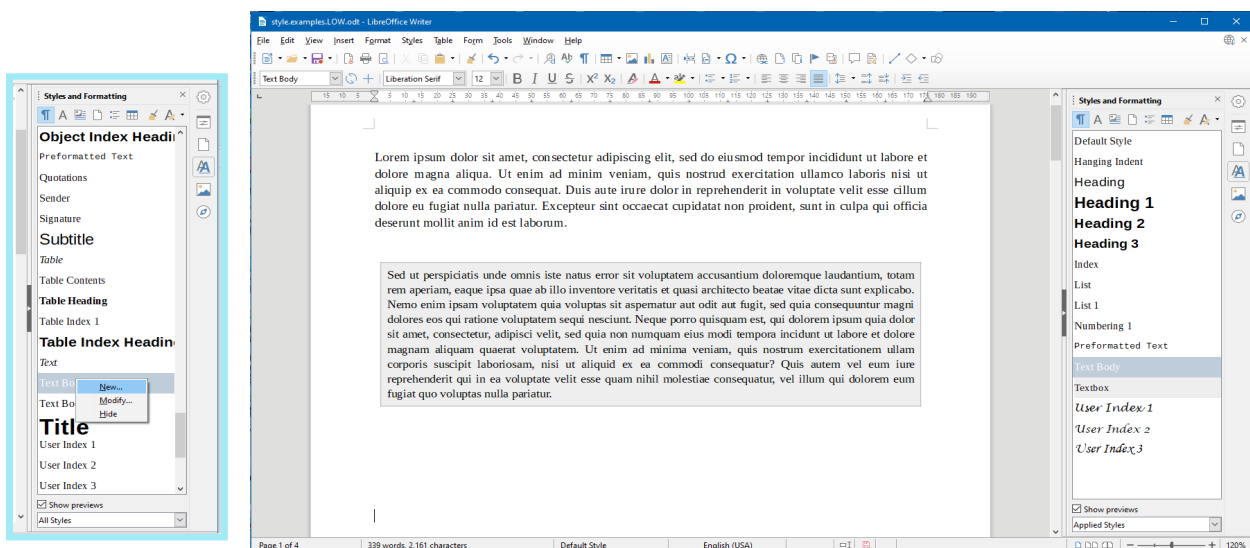


A table of contents (TOC) from my textbook, with the table of contents styles in the sidebar; the TOC styles (**Contents 1**, **Contents 2**) are generated from the header styles (**Heading 1**, **Heading 2**) in the document. This screenshot is from another PC, with LibreOffice in a dark theme (from the menu bar, find **Tools > Options** and then appearance settings to select the dark theme). On the left is another sidebar with the Navigator view, for document outline and structure.

Creating new styles

You can easily create custom styles in LO Writer. You can create a style from scratch, or one based on an existing style. Let's start with a new style based on an existing one. Let's say I want to create a text box style based on the main paragraph text style. First, we need to make sure that in the drop-down menu, "All Styles" is selected to see the new style. Then in the sidebar, I will right-click on my main text style, **Body Text** (or **Text Body / Text Body Single** in older versions of LO), and select **New** to create a new style based on the old one. In the General tab, I will give it a unique name. On the Area tab, I can determine a color background. On the Border tab, I can give it a border, chose the border style and thickness, and distance between the text and the border. Maybe in the Font tab, I give it a slightly smaller font size, and on the Position tab, I can make the text spacing a bit more compact. After saving the new style, I can highlight a paragraph and apply the new style.

The older parent style is **Body Text**, and the new child style (a new style created from an existing style) that I've created is called **Textbox**. Now if I make changes to the parent style, those changes will apply or percolate down to the child style, except for specific changes that I've made in the child style. For example, if I did not change the font family in the child (**Textbox**) and only the font size in the child (let's say, Times New Roman), then if I change the font family in the parent **Body Text** style (say, from Times New Roman to Century Schoolbook) and also the font size, only the font family in the child (**Textbox**) style should be affected by this change. Because the child **Textbox** has its own custom font size, that should not be affected by changes in the parent style. Or at least that is the way it is supposed to work in LibreOffice.

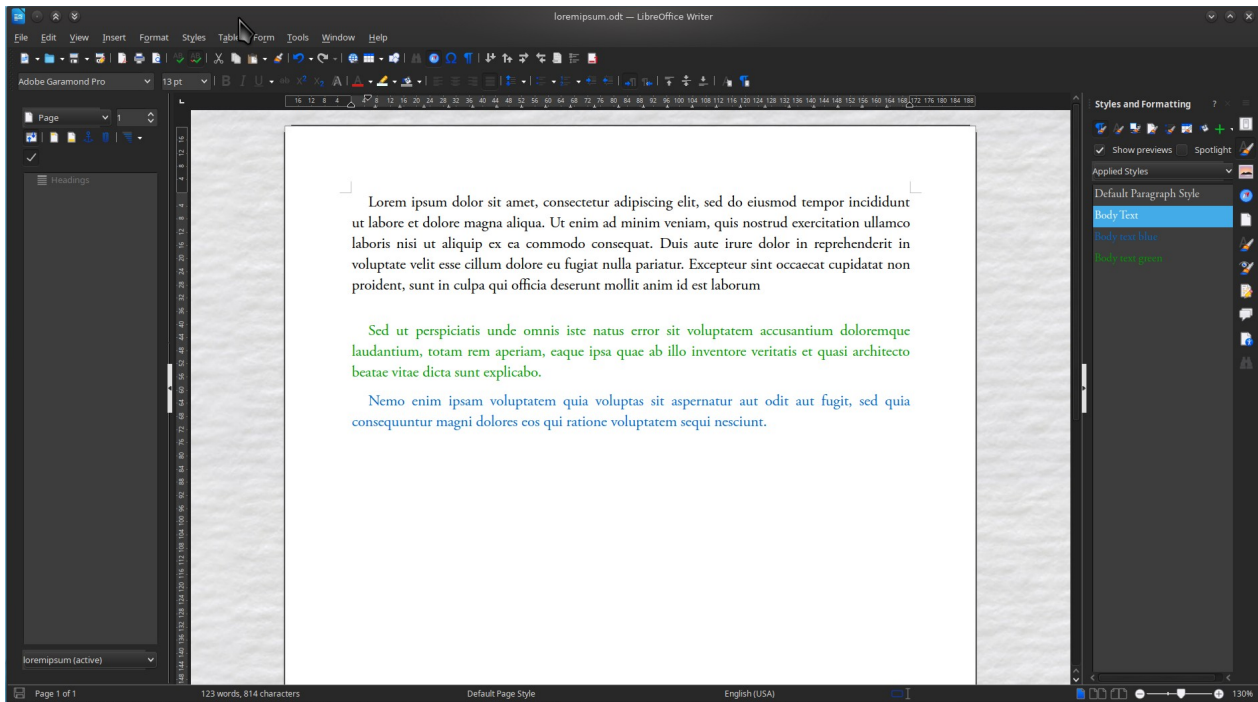


On the left: the paragraph styles; right-click on a style and select **New** to create a new style from it. The result on the right is a new custom style called **Textbox**; in the document, you can see the normal **Body Text** in the first paragraph, followed by a paragraph in **Textbox** style. The **Textbox** style was also modified with a background color in the Area tab of the style editing dialogue, and with a border in the Borders tab.

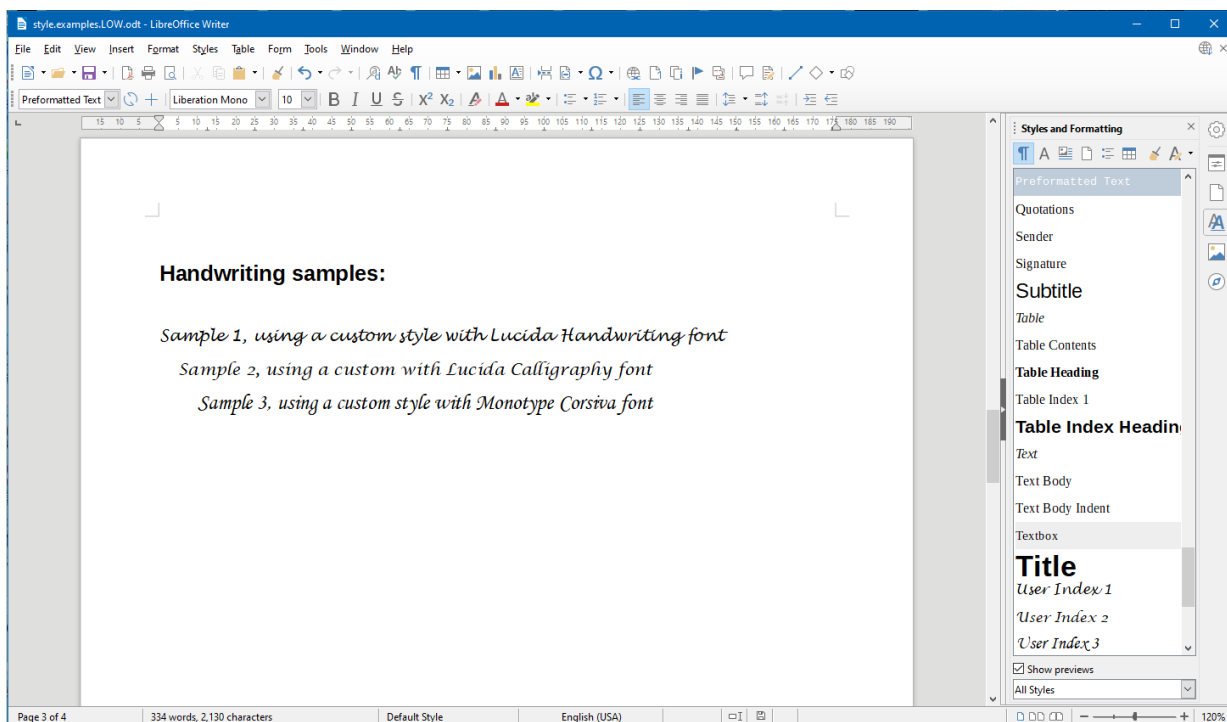
You may want to set up different body paragraph styles—for example, a regular body paragraph with a standard 12 mm tab indentation, and one with no indentation. You might like custom styles for paragraphs or text blocks with shading, borders, special font attributes, and such. There are predefined styles for block quotations, or you might like to create your own.

Now let's create a totally new style that is not based on a previously used style. The best option for this is to start with one of the basic, general default styles, namely, the one called [Default Text](#) or [Default Paragraph Style](#). This is the basic general default, and in fact other default styles like [Body Text](#) are based on it. I right-click on it to select [New](#) for a wholly new style, give it a name, and make all the modifications that I want in the various tabs. This is something I might do for a completely different or novel type of paragraph or text block. For example, if I am writing an academic paper and need to format it according to the publisher's specifications, I will create a bunch of unique styles for special sections of the document, like [Abstract](#), [Keywords](#), [Cited Examples](#), and such, all based on a default style. Or maybe I want to create special styles for entire paragraphs or text blocks with green or blue text in the entire bloc (see below). Or for my textbook, I need text samples in a handwriting font that look like writing samples. I can create custom styles from the default style, with a unique style for each writing sample (see below).

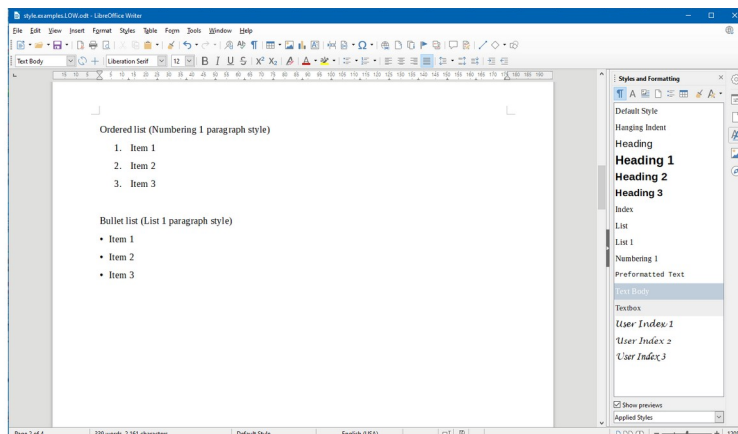
Then if changes need to be made to a particular style throughout the document, you can easily select the style in the sidebar, chose [Edit Style](#), make your changes, and see them automatically applied. The way you apply changes to a paragraph style holds true for other style types below, that is, for character styles and page styles. The way you modify and create new styles from existing ones is also the same for character styles, page styles, and other style types in LibreOffice.



Some new text styles for blue and green text, created based on the **Body Text** style, with the boring names of **Body text blue** and **Body text green**. The styles apply to entire paragraphs. I also added an automatic paragraph indentation (**Edit Style > Indents & Spacing**, choose 'First Line' and enter a few millimeters as desired).

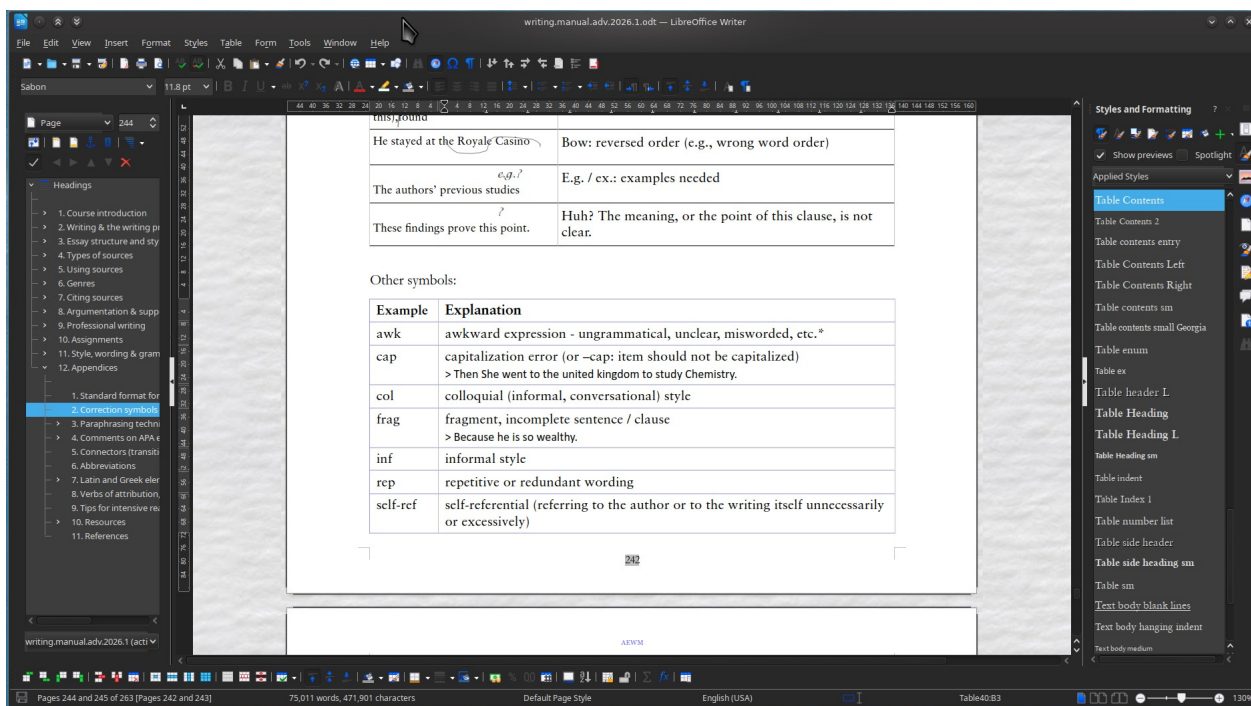


Some custom handwriting fonts, from modified **User Index** styles.



Tables

- The top headers of the table
- Additional left-side headers in a more complex table, maybe with left justification
- The main table text in the cells
- Table legend, footnote, or caption
- Table titles or labels (e.g., "Table 1: Preliminary data")
- Table index and headers, if you have a list or index of tables after the table of contents



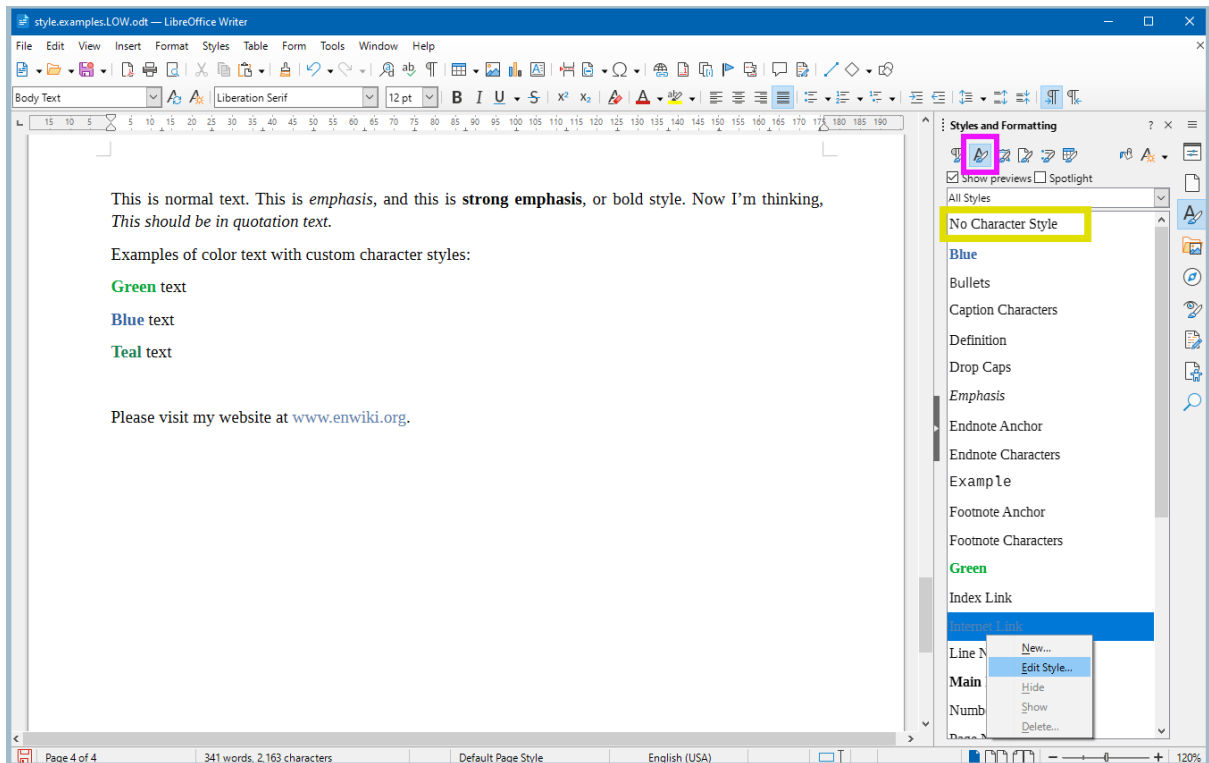
A table from my textbook, with various table styles. The styles **Table Contents**, **Table Heading**, **Table Index 1** come as defaults. I have created a number of custom styles as well. On the left, I have the Navigator sidebar, which is very convenient for working with long, complex documents.

Character styles

Character styles are for adding or changing formatting on particular characters, words, or phrases within a paragraph or text block, that is, formatting that differs from the rest of the paragraph or text block.

In the sidebar, under the **Styles and Formatting** deck, look again at the icons at the top, arranged from left to right, and select the second from the right, the icon for the character styles menu. Click that, and you see a scrollbar again to choose to see all the predefined character styles that come with LibreOffice (All Styles), or just the ones currently applied to your document (Applied Styles). In the list of styles, the very first one is **No Character Style**. This is the base default, e.g., for no character styling at all, and it is the parent style for all the other character styles. If you see a character style applied to some text and want to remove it, then highlight the text with the mouse, and click or double-click on **No Character Style** to remove character styling. This is different from **Ctrl-M** (or right-click and **Remove special styles**), which only removes direct styling, that is, styling applied manually to text without applying defined character styles.

You will see a number of styles for emphasis (italics), strong emphasis (bold), lists, captions, and others that you can use for bits of text within a paragraph or block. You might want to define your own.



The Character Style selector is the icon highlighted in magenta. Right below that is a drop-down menu to show All Styles or Applied Styles. The **No Character Style** is highlighted in gold. You can see when you right-click on a style, you see a pop-up menu to edit the style or create a new style based on the existing style.

The character styles menu will be useful when pasting in text from another document or from a web page. It is also useful to apply italics, boldface and other styles to words in a more intelligent manner. Often when you paste text into a document, the word processor will interpret the text according to invisible tags or styling that it had in the original, especially if it is pasted from a different program, or from a web page. For example, italic text on a web page is probably marked with an `<em>` tag in the HTML code for emphasis, or with the more general `<i>` tag for italics instead in the HTML code. LibreOffice will interpret all of these as italics, but maybe also with character style definitions, which you can see in the Character Style section of the sidebar.

One common issue arises when I paste in text from a web page containing hyperlinks. LO interprets links and assigns them the Internet Link character style, with underlined blue text. I have to edit the **Internet Link** style in the Character Styles editor to turn off the underlining, and maybe alter the font color or font family settings.

Character style options

Now if you go about manually styling it as italics in your LO document with the manual italics option (via **Ctrl-I**; via the toolbar italics button; or by highlighting, right-clicking, and selecting italics), you can encounter problems in longer documents. There are different types

or uses of italics, and it helps to have separate styles defined for different types, so you can manage and edit these separately. Italics can be used for:

- Emphasis (emphatic meaning) or contrast
- Highlighting keywords, such as new technical terms (common in textbooks, reference works, and manuals)
- Citing, quoting, or using words out of context, or as different parts of speech (e.g., "We want no *if's*, *and's* or *but's*.")
- Foreign terms
- Scientific names of species
- Reported internal thought, for example, what a character in a story is thinking
- Book titles and titles of periodicals
- Titles of films, TV shows, and songs
- Names of specific vehicles and ships

You can refer to the previous screenshot, where italic and bold styles are applied with the [Emphasis](#), [Strong Emphasis](#), and [Quotation](#) styles.

If your document is long or complex, and you have different types of italic text, you might want to create custom styles in the character styles menu for different types of italics, and apply them to the appropriate words. Then if you need to change the style on one type of italics, you can modify the character style for just that text type throughout the whole document. If you used one character style for scientific names of species, and you want to then change it from black italic text to a dark green italic text throughout the whole document, you can modify only that style, and all such words in the text will automatically update to green italics. Other italic text marked with a different style (like an [Emphasis](#) style) will not be affected.

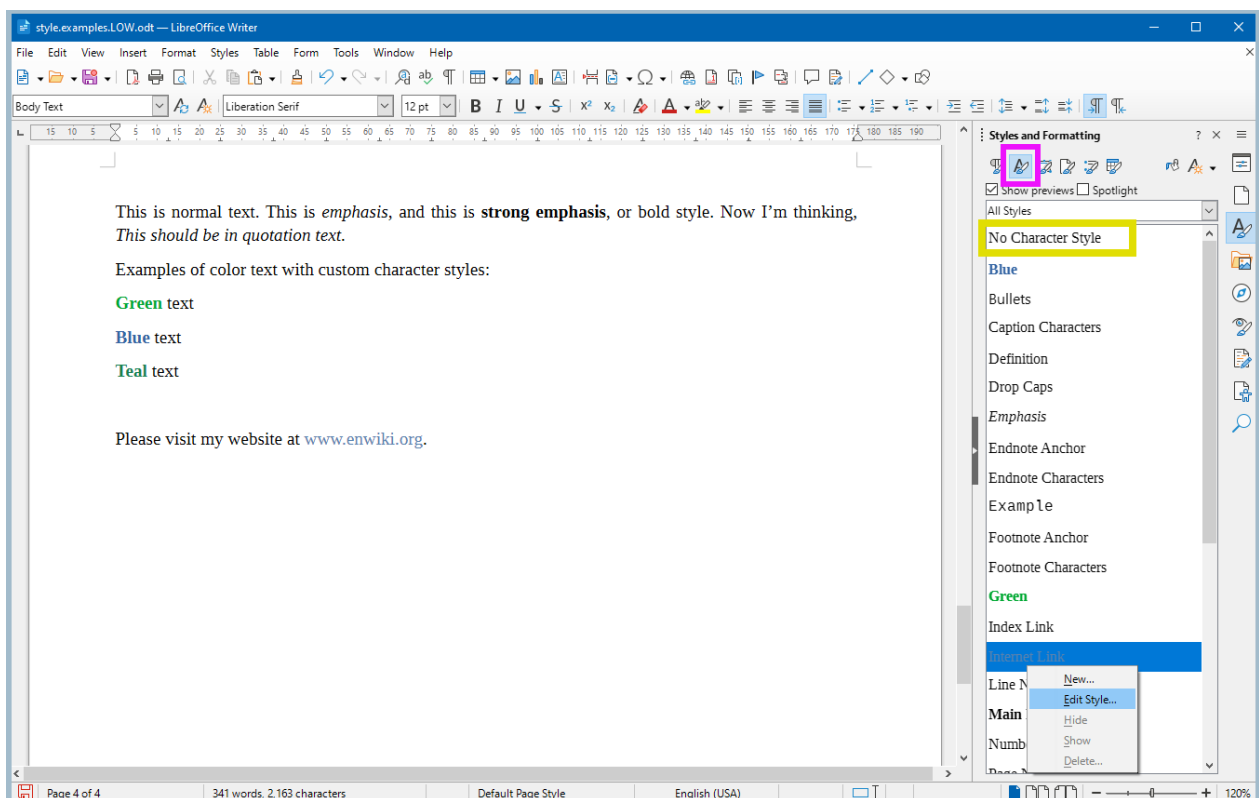
Finally, to remove character styles, highlight the desired text, and double-click on the default, labelled [No Character Style](#), or maybe [Default Style](#) in earlier LO versions, to remove all Character styles. This should not affect paragraph styles, page styles, or manually applied direct styling.

Predefined Character styles

The predefined character styles include the following. Note: Text may be indicated as [No Character Style](#) regardless of direct styling that was applied, and in spite of any predefined paragraph styles that were applied.

- **No Character Style:** This is the basic default, for text with no other character-level format styles applied
- **Bullets:** This defines the appearance, positioning and spacing of bullets
- **Definition,** for word definitions; you might like to customize this with boldface, italics, or font colors

- **Drop Caps**
- **Emphasis:** Normal italics for emphasis and contrast
- **Endnote Anchor, Footnote Anchor:** For the appearance of the superscripted footnote or endnote number within the main text
- **Endnote / Footnote Text:** The text within the footnote or endnote
- **Internet Link, Visited Internet Link:** The appearance and style of URL links; you may want to remove underlining, change the font color (blue by default, or red for visited links), or font family
- **Main Index Entry:** For items in a document index (like an index of terms in the back of a book) that is automatically generated with the LO indexing tool
- **Quotation:** In italics by default, but you can change this.
- **Page number:** The appearance and spacing of the page numbers
- **Source Text, Teletype:** Useful for code examples in sentences within a paragraph of regular text
- **Strong emphasis:** In bold font by default
- **Title.publication:** For publication titles
- **User Entry:** For whatever you like



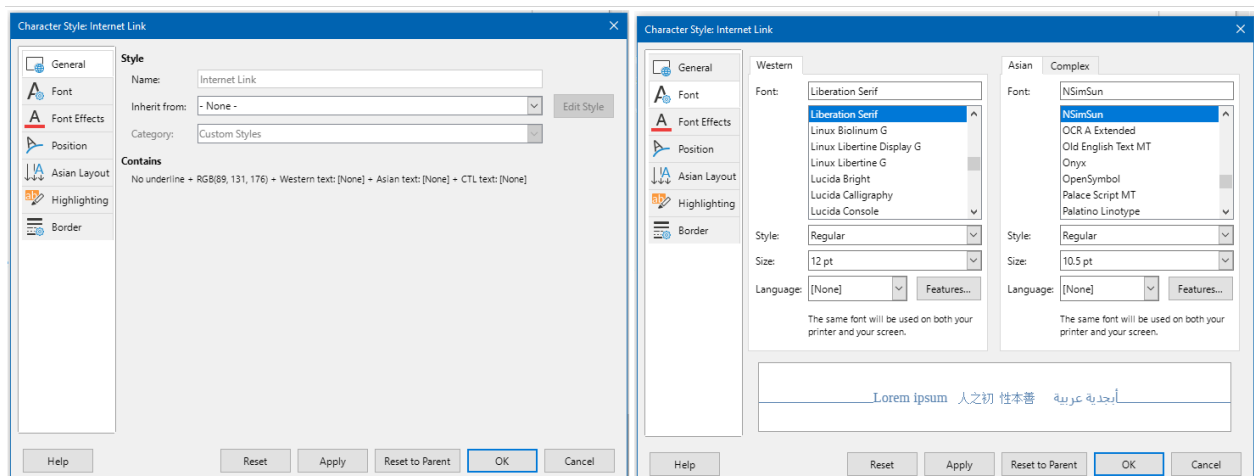
In this same screenshot, you can see some of the predefined styles, and a few custom styles, such as colored text.

Modifying and creating new styles

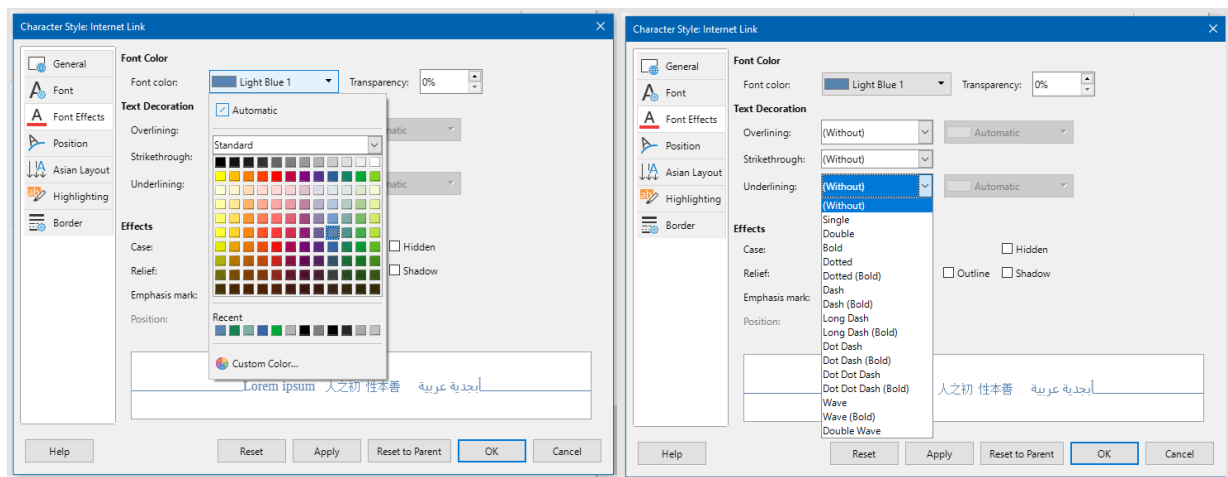
You can right-click on an existing style and choose **Edit Style** to modify it. Changes there will be applied to all instances of that style throughout the documents. You can highlight text with the mouse and double-click on the style in the Character Style Editor sidebar to apply the style to the text (similar to applying paragraph styles).

You can create a new character style based on an existing style. The parent style features will be shared with the new child style that you create, except maybe for features that you change in the child style (just as for new paragraph styles). You can also create a new style based on **No Character Style** for a totally new or unique style. You will see the following options for features that you can play with:

- **General:** The name of the style (predefined LO styles cannot be renamed), and its parent style
- **Font:** Font size and family
- **Font effects:** Font color, underlining, strikethrough effects, case (upper or lower case, all capitals), shadow text, and others
- **Position:** Superscript or subscript size, rotation, character scaling and spacing
- **Highlighting**, that is, just highlighting the selected text, rather than a whole paragraph or text block (a paragraph style would be used for a whole text block)
- **Border:** You can put a border around characters of a customized style, and specify the border type and spacing between the text and border. This is for characters with that style, not for an entire text block (for a whole text block, you would use the Border option of a paragraph style).
- **Asian Text Layout** for Eastern Asian languages



Character Styles editor: The General tab, where you can name a new custom style (left), and the basic font attributes in the Font tab (right).

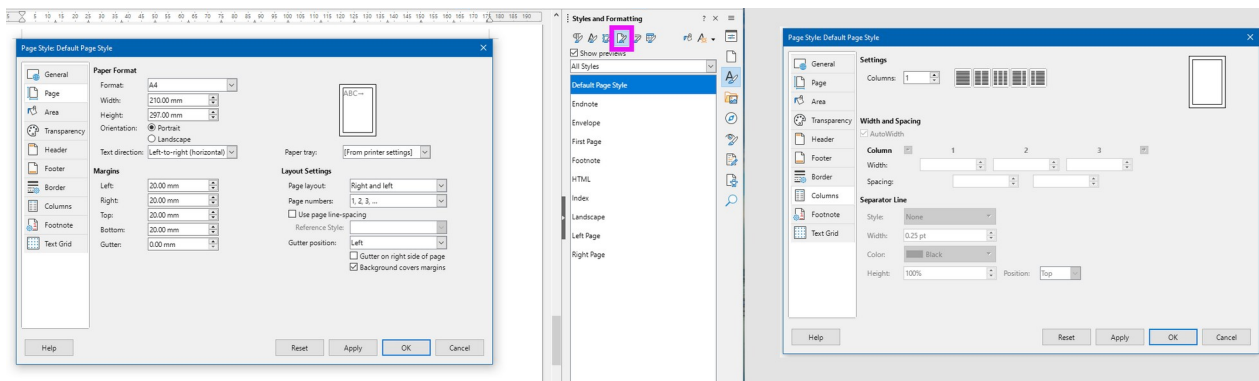


Character Styles editor, Font Effects tab, where you can adjust text color, underlining, and others.

Page styles

Different parts of the document can have different page styles. In the sidebar, the fourth icon from the left is for page styles (we skipped one icon for text frames, which are not covered here). You can change the margins, orientation, and other properties here. To apply a page style to a page, place the cursor on the page, and double-click on the desired page style in the sidebar menu. The default page styles include:

- **Default Page Style:** The basic default page style
- **Endnote** and **Footnote** for customizing those sections of a document
- **First page:** Useful if you want the first page(s) of a book to not have page numbers, to not be included in the page numbering of the whole document, or to have different page numbers (like small Roman numerals for page numbers when other pages have regular numerals).
- **Left Page, Right Page:** For customizing pages on the right and left side of a book. This can be useful for setting different page margins on left and right pages; for separate, different running headers at the top of the left and right pages; or to turn off page numbering or headers on one side
- **Envelope** printing
- **Index:** For a document index (or other sections like a table of contents)
- **Landscape** orientation for a particular page
- **Text grid** for creating text grid lines, for example, for engineering paper, graph paper, or boxes to write in for, say, letter writing examples and exercises.



Left: The Paragraph styles icon is highlighted in magenta; below that, the All Styles or Applied Styles drop-down, and then the common predefined styles. In the paragraph style editor, the general Page layout tab is shown, for paper type, layout, and margins.

Right: The Columns tab, where newspaper style or magazine style columns can be set up.

Default page styles

You can right-click to edit or create a new page style, and you can start with Default Page Style for a totally new, unique page style. Creating and modifying page styles works just like for paragraph and character styles. In the Page Style editor, you will see the following options in the top tabs or sidebar:

- **General:** Page name and parent default page style; here you can name a custom style.
- **Page:** Paper format (A4 paper, US letter, and such), and margins
- **Area:** For adding background colors or patterns to entire pages
- **Header, Footer:** For page numbers or running book / article titles in the page header (top of the page) or footer (bottom of page). Check the box for "Header on" to turn on page headers, and "Footer on" for page footers.
- **Border** for page borders
- **Columns:** Here you can split text on a page (or part of a page) into two or more columns
- **Footnote:** Some footnote properties, such as spacing, whether longer footnotes get split across a page break), and whether a short horizontal line separates the footnote section from the body text

Headers, footers, and page numbers

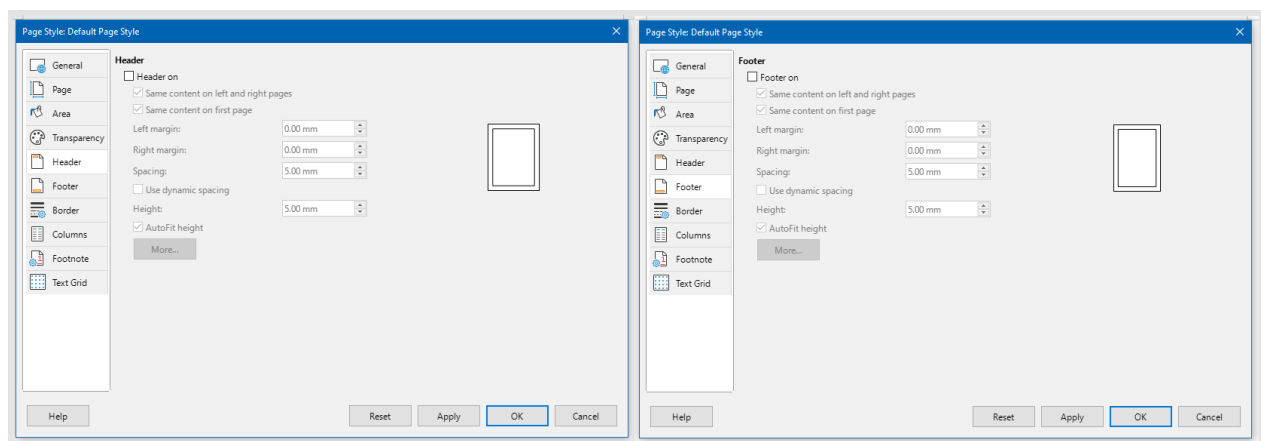
Headers and footers can be used at the top or bottom of pages for page numbers, footnotes, running title headers (for example, book titles at the top of the page), and other marginalia. First, you need to activate the header or footer by editing the page style in which you want them. Right-click on the page style, go to the Header or Footer tab, and activate it. You can customize its height and spacing from the rest of the page elements or margins in the tab as well. After applying the changes, you will see a new Header or Footer field in the document.

You can simply type text in for a running title header, or whatever text you like. You can then customize the text appearance by going to the Paragraph styles menu, find the Header or Footer style, and customize it. You can also choose Header Left/Right or Footer Left/Right and customize them, so you can have separate left and right header or footer elements.

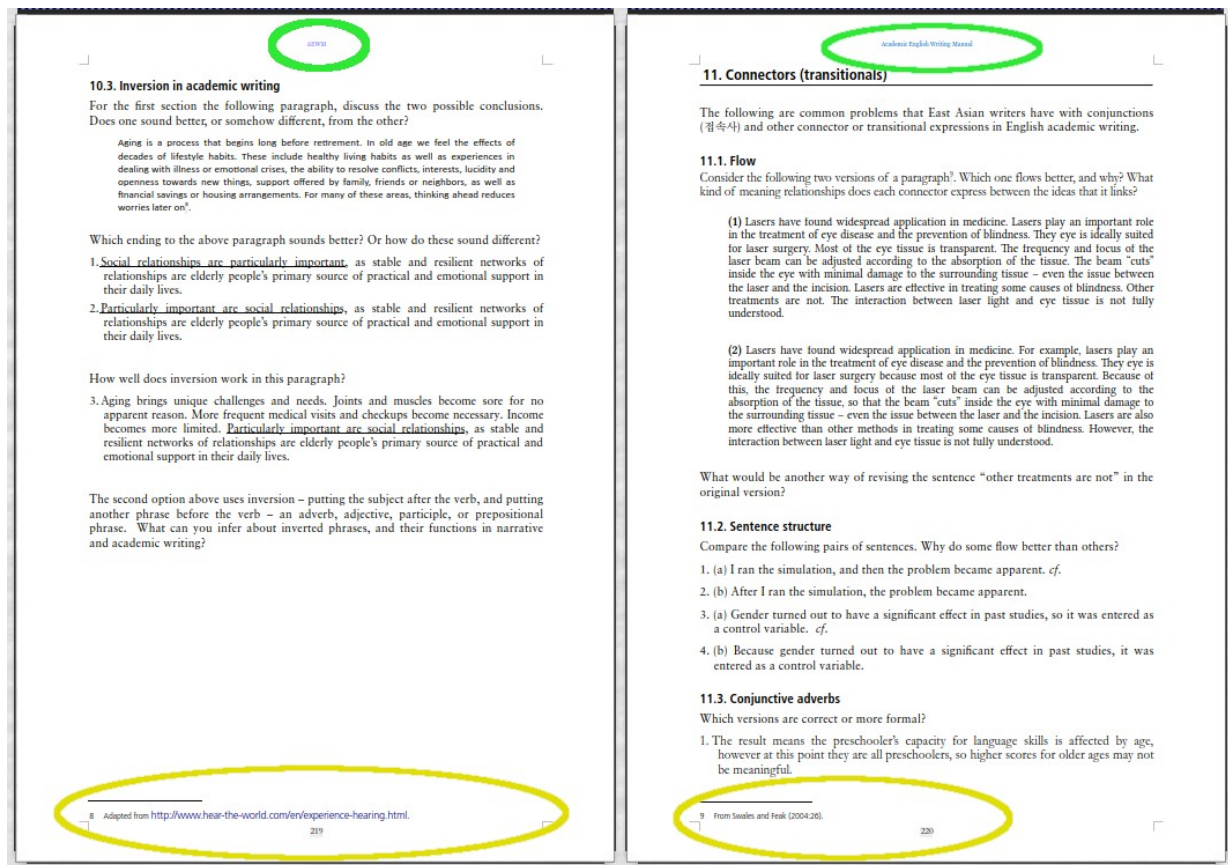
To insert page numbers, you need to first activate the page header or footer, depending on where you want to put the page numbers on the top or bottom of the page. Then from the main LO menu at the top, find the page number options under the 'Insert' menu; there are two options:

- **Insert > Page Number:** This is easier, but I find this does not work as well, or is not as easy to modify.
- **Insert > Field > Page Number:** This option tends to work better, and it is easier to modify the page number formatting.

Then make sure that a paragraph style like Footnote or Footer is applied to the page number (you may need to highlight it with the mouse and apply a style). A paragraph style is needed, rather than a character style, so that the style applies consistently to all page numbers in the document. You can modify its positioning, alignment, and font style.



Page style editor: The header and footer tabs.



Pages from my textbook, showing running book title headers at the top, with different left and right page headers, circled in green. At the bottom are footnotes and page number fields, circled in yellow.

Other style options

In the Styles sidebar, there are other options that you can also play with:

- Frames style for text frame objects
- List style menu for further formatting and layout of bulleted and numbered lists
- Tables style menu to define, modify, and apply table style, layout and features to various tables in a document, such as general layout, cell background, table cell and row lines, line styles, and cell borders. This is in addition to the font features defined for table text in the paragraph styles menu.

Conclusion

LibreOffice writer really shines in the power it allows users to define and apply styles at the character, paragraph, and page level, and then easily modify features for a defined style throughout an entire document all at once. This makes style management easier, and makes it a lot easier to create larger and more documents, such as novels, textbooks, user manuals, technical documentation, research papers, and other genres.